



FLYING CARPET FESTIVAL 2026 Artist Handbook

August 21 – September 1, 2026
Mardin, Türkiye / Turkish Syrian Border Region

At a Glance

- **Arrival:** August 20, 2026
- **Rehearsals and preparations:** August 21-22
- **Performances:** August 23 – September 1, 2026
- **Departure:** September 2, 2026
- **Airport:** Prof. Dr. Aziz Sancar Airport (MQM)
- **Accommodation:** Shared double and triple rooms in Mardin's Old City
- **Main communication:** 2026 Flying Carpet Festival Artists WhatsApp group
- **Key Contacts (Coordinators):** Pegah Karimnejad — +49 1578 0272480/ Azim Moollan — +230 5729 8960

Festival Schedule

- **August 20:** Artist arrival in Old Mardin (Eski Mardin).
- **August 21–22:** Rehearsal days dedicated to *The Little Prince* production.
- **August 23–31: Community Tour** — eight days of workshops, performances, and community activities across local towns:
 - Aug 23: İstasyon
 - Aug 24: Midyat
 - Aug 25: Derik
 - Aug 26: Gökçe
 - Aug 27: Ortaköy
 - Aug 29: Çınar
 - Aug 30: Midyat (return visit)
 - Aug 31: Nusaybin
- **Special evening events:**
 - Aug 28: Assyrian Community JAM Night at Kırklar Church (Old Mardin).
 - Sept 1: Public JAM Night at İz Mekan (Old Mardin).
- **September 2:** Festival wrap-up and artist departure.

Before You Arrive Checklist

- Check visa requirements and contact the coordinators immediately if you need support.
- Confirm luggage transfer details with your airline, especially if connecting through Istanbul.
- Join the 2026 Flying Carpet Festival Artists WhatsApp group.
- Share one emergency contact with the coordination team.
- Inform your embassy of your travel dates and location.
- Pack your passport, medication, sun protection, modest clothing, comfortable shoes, and any essential performance or workshop materials.
- Inform a coordinator immediately about any flight changes, early arrival, late departure, or decision not to use festival housing.



Dear Artist,

Welcome to the 8th edition of Flying Carpet Festival. We are grateful to have you join our international community of artists, change-makers, and storytellers as we bring art, imagination, and shared creation to children and communities living in some of the world's most challenging conditions.

Please read this handbook before your arrival. It covers arrival and departure dates, safety and conduct expectations, local conditions, communication channels, and what the festival provides. We look forward to welcoming you to Mardin on **August 20, 2026**.

About the Festival

Flying Carpet Festival is a volunteer-driven, artist-led mobile arts initiative near the Turkish Syrian border. Since 2018, it has brought together musicians, dancers, storytellers, circus performers, designers, puppeteers, and visual artists to co-create meaningful experiences for displaced and vulnerable children.

The festival is produced with **Sirkhane Social Circus School**, a local NGO using circus, music, and art to empower children and youth affected by conflict and displacement. The Circus Heroes—Syrian youth who grew up with Sirkhane—are central to the festival and perform alongside international artists and musicians.

Each edition is shaped by a shared theme. In 2026, the narrative is inspired by Antoine de Saint-Exupéry's *The Little Prince*, exploring imagination, friendship, responsibility, and the invisible bonds that connect us across borders through performance, music, circus, puppetry, design, and storytelling.

Flying Carpet is proudly non-political, non-religious, and non-ideological. We believe in art as a universal language for empathy, understanding, and healing.

Location and Daily Life

Artists will be based in **Mardin**, an ancient city in southeastern Türkiye near the Syrian border, known for its cultural diversity, architecture, and spiritual heritage. Although the region is historically complex and may be classified as a “red zone” by some foreign embassies, Sirkhane has operated safely in Mardin for more than 14 years with the support of local communities and authorities.

Accommodation will be in shared double and triple rooms in Mardin's Old City from August 20 to September 2. Conditions are modest rather than luxurious; please arrive ready for a simple, communal, and deeply human experience. If you plan to arrive earlier or depart later on your own expense, contact one of the coordinators in advance to arrange and pay for any extra housing days. If you do not intend to use the festival housing option, you are responsible for informing the coordination team as soon as possible.

Each day, the group will travel by bus or van to cities, towns, villages, and mobile centers across Mardin province for performances and workshops. Sirkhane's Old City center will be our shared base for meetings, rehearsals, jam



sessions, community dinners, and nightly reflections. For artists who want more context, we have also provided a separate document on the mythological and cultural history of Mardin province.

Guidelines and Code of Conduct

Mardin is welcoming and culturally rich. To protect our relationships with local communities and help everyone move through the region with care, please follow these essentials:

Attire and Field Conduct

- **Carry your passport at all times.**
- In Mardin and at your accommodation, wear what feels comfortable and true to your taste.
- On the field—for workshops, performances, and parades—please wear **modest, covering, beautiful, and colorful semi-formal clothes.**
- Please avoid flip-flops, shorts, sport attire and branded T-shirts during festival activities.
- Smoking is **strictly prohibited** on the field, in our center, and anywhere children are present.
- Bring flexibility, patience, respect, and a collaborative spirit every day.
- Follow festival team and local authority guidance during travel, performances, and community visits.
- Prepare for late-August heat above 35°C / 95°F: wear light, modest, breathable clothing with coverage; use sunscreen; stay hydrated; and drink only bottled water.
- Respect local customs: dress modestly in public; avoid public political or religious debates; do not post about Turkish political affairs; and do not tag sensitive locations while traveling or working with communities.
- For safety and community comfort, avoid highly visible political symbols in public, including national party logos, campaign slogans, protest imagery, and flags or emblems linked to political movements. Please also avoid clothing or accessories with highly visible LGBTQIA+ flags or advocacy symbols in public settings.
- Inform your embassy of your travel dates and location before arrival.

Zero-Tolerance Policy

Flying Carpet Festival has zero tolerance for:

- Possession or use of illegal drugs or substances.
- Sexual harassment, misconduct, or abuse of any kind.
- Verbal or physical abuse, bullying, or intimidation.
- Disrespectful behavior toward children, staff, artists, or community members.

Any violation will result in **immediate dismissal from the festival**, loss of accommodation, and, if necessary, involvement of local authorities. We are committed to protecting a safe environment for everyone, especially the vulnerable communities we serve.

Travel Information

- **Arrival:** Artists must arrive on August 20, 2026, so the full group can begin together.
- **Festival dates:** August 21 – September 1, 2026.
- **Departure:** Please plan to depart on September 2, 2026, after the festival program concludes.
- **Local airport:** Prof. Dr. Aziz Sancar Airport (MQM).
- **Luggage:** You may need to collect your luggage in Istanbul and re-check it for the domestic flight to Mardin. Confirm with your airline.



- **Flight changes:** Artists are responsible for any changes to their flights. If your itinerary changes for any reason, inform one of the coordinators immediately.
- **Visas:** Check visa requirements [here](#). If you need a visa, you should already have heard from a coordinator. If you need one and have not heard from us, contact us immediately. We will provide a formal invitation letter and any other required documentation.
- **Insurance:** Please arrange personal travel and medical insurance before arrival.

What to Bring

- Passport and any required visa documents.
- Personal medication and basic health items.
- Lightweight, modest clothing suitable for high heat.
- Comfortable shoes (not flip-flops) for travel, workshops, and outdoor sites.
- Hat, sunglasses, sunscreen, and a refillable water bottle.
- Any essential performance materials, instruments, or workshop supplies you are responsible for bringing.

What We Provide

- **Flights:** Round-trip flights to and from Mardin.
- **Accommodation:** Shared double and triple rooms from August 20 to September 2. Extra housing days caused by personal early arrival or late departure are the artist's responsibility and must be arranged with the coordinators in advance.
- **Meals:** Breakfast, lunch, and dinner prepared by our kitchen team.
- **Local transport:** Transport for all official festival activities.
- **Visa fees:** Reimbursement of visa application fees, if applicable.
- **Airport transfer expenses:** For any transportation expense to or from the airport in your home city, please provide us with a receipt for reimbursement.

Communication

- **SIM cards:** We recommend an e-SIM with international data. Reliable providers include Airalo and Holafly. If you prefer a physical SIM, you can buy one at Istanbul Airport or in Mardin.
- **Festival coordination:** All communication before and during the festival will take place in the 2026 Flying Carpet Festival Artists WhatsApp group. If you have not been added, please contact us.
- **Questions:** Contact the coordinators by WhatsApp or email.
- **Emergency contact:** Please share one emergency contact with the coordination team before arrival. During the festival, contact the coordinators immediately in any urgent situation.
 - **Pegah Karimnejad — +49 1578 0272480**
 - **Azim Moollan — +230 5729 8960**

Thank you for bringing your openness, courage, and artistry to this journey. We are honored to create, travel, and share beauty with you where it is most needed.

With love and respect,

The Flying Carpet Festival Team